“Dreams of Unthought Thoughts”

The world was a bunch of tired monkeys and worn-out typewriters.

Their job was done—that’s what every citizen in Geopolis felt like. So they didn’t try any art. They lived and worked until they were old and died, just like everyone else.

Yuan tried once. She picked up her pencil and pressed it a specific way on the paper. Then she couldn’t shake the feeling someone on the other side of the world pressed it the same exact way, down to the individual molecule, with the same plan in their mind for the outcome of the drawing. She shuddered and impulsively crumpled the paper and threw it in the trash. Then she melted down at the thought that a million others probably did the same, and that a million more others probably suffered the same breakdown she was about to—and that if she chose *not* to suffer the breakdown, a million more others did that too.

She didn’t want to go to the doctor because she already knew what she had: Unoriginal Disorder. The doctor probably diagnosed it to people a thousand times per day.

#

The first time Yuan met <NAME> in university, she was burning a pile of books. As the information was deleted from the universe, Yuan imagined the words floating off the pages, drifting into the sky, forever lost.

<NAME> told her about her life. She started destroying books five years ago, but the reason why started when she was young.

The first time she experienced Geopolis’s oversaturation was regrettably local. There was a school assignment to write a short story for English class, and she and another girl, uninfluenced by each other, came up with the same idea. The other girl won because the teacher just liked the writing better, and <NAME> was furious. Although she couldn’t prove it, <NAME> believed the other girl copied her.

When she was 18, she read Borges’s “The Library of Babel.” It was a story about a library that already contained all possible combinations of the letters of the alphabet in its books, along with some punctuation. She immediately resonated with it, interpreting it as a story about modern Geopolis. Ideas were numerous and overdone, and there were no free ones left. Everything that could be written had already been written.

When she was 21, she started to see patterns in every story she heard and every piece of art she saw. She studied chains of inspiration in works: Alexander Selkirk’s adventures to *Robinson Crusoe* to *Lord of the Flies* to *The Hunger Games* to *Crimson Descent*, last century’s critically acclaimed battle royale video game. In museums, she read plaques about artists who borrowed painting techniques from each other and how each painting had a story to tell about past influences.

She realized she had seen every archetype of every character, experienced every emotion. There was nothing left to discover. She no longer found joy when she started a new game or watched a new movie. She felt empty.

“As a whole, Geopolis doesn’t believe in achieving immortal-like lifespans,” said <NAME>. “We have laws against it. We don’t want to overcrowd the city planet so much that we can’t make room for new lives. Five years ago I wondered the same thing about ideas. Everyone in Geopolis these days is losing interest in the latest blockbusters in theatres. Each one can be traced back to another remake or sequel from a previous century, and that remake or sequel can be traced back to another, and so on. Imagine if people were unaware of these chains, if we could restart entirely every century. I believe we could be so much happier. That’s when I started

applying our logic about the population to ideas. We must burn ideas to make room for new voices, so that they can be endlessly reused without the knowledge of them being reused."

She told Yuan about the beauty of the prehistoric peoples she saw in museums. The unimaginable euphoria of exploring undiscovered lands, creating new tools like fire, and making the first paintings. To place a handprint on a cave wall and find comfort in the certainty of being able to say, "I was the first to ever make this."

Yuan argued with her that she was wrong. There were still countless ideas left to discover. Names left to be imprinted on history, and any one of them could be theirs.

But she found it hard to believe herself. Geopolis was so populous that there were online groups for doppelgangers numbering in the tens of thousands. Many suffered jealousy at hearing that their doppelgangers lived better lives, that they had a more beautiful wife or handsome husband, or that they made more money even when they had the same job.

"It's funny," Yuan told <NAME>. "You burning a pile of books. It reminds me of a scene from a really old novel—something called *Fahrenheit 451*. It was popular back in the day, in Old Earth. Have you heard of it?"

<NAME> scoffed at her remark. Yuan realized her mistake. That's when she knew they weren't going to be friends.

#

It has been said that given infinite time, a monkey typing random keys on a typewriter will eventually recreate all the works of Shakespeare or Zenith Lang.

It has also been depicted that a library, made with the ingenious use of mathematical algorithms, could generate every possible permutation of the 26 letters of the Latin alphabet, a space, comma, and a period to contain anything that could ever be said or written in the history and future of mankind.

The difference between the two is one needs time to create the specific works one is looking for, and the other already has them existing on its bookshelves, one just has to find them. But both, in theory, have everything that could ever be created by the Latin language.

In this world of a million billion people, are we still the monkey on the typewriter, searching for the perfect art, or have we already discovered everything that could ever be written and are more like the endless library? I suppose that depends on whether Geopolis is truly eternal. If it is not, fate would certainly deem that we are not monkeys. But with the addition of Feeder World #132 dedicated to the trending new gengineered starlyre fruit, the security of our city strengthens and it gets harder to doubt that Geopolis will be timeless.

I call the individuals who advocate for their favourite school of thought either Monkeys or Librarians respectively. There is a guild of snobby artists that everyone in Geopolis knows called the Seekers of Creativity. They are an international alliance of Monkeys. Their goal is to continue their futile search for true originality. The rest of Geopolis, the overwhelming majority of its citizens, are Librarians who believe we already live in the library.

These words are not mine. I am borrowing them from the last person to have written this exact sequence of letters, their memory lost to the stream of time. I am a Librarian as well, but I write like I am a Monkey. It's all I know how to do.

—Solonax the Infinite-#LVII, *Stories Ad Infinitum,* Chapter 1
Discovered and translated by Zia Harper-#6847 from the ancient gardens of Nova Hortus in the North-Ellesmere Subdistrict

#

Seeker Officer Yuan removed the black hood over the civilian's face, allowing him to see the blinding headlights aimed at him in the dark room.

"State your name for the permanent record."

"My name is Marvin Snow."

"What do you do for a living, Mr. Snow?"

"I… Um, I'm just a baker. But I also write on the side."

"Do you understand why you are here today?"

"I think so."

"Do you know what us Seekers do?"

"Of course. Everyone in Geopolis knows about you."

"We raided your home at 9:52 pm. A few hours earlier, we were notified that some people believed you had thought of a truly original idea. What do you have to say about that?"

"Oh, well, I don't know. My family just likes to say that, but they're *family*, you know?"

Yuan looked at the one-way mirror behind her and said, "How much longer for the Babelios scan?"

A voice spoke in her earpiece. "It just finished. It's not looking good. The idea for his arrest was a story about cats with magenta boots forced to fight an evil Queen of Mirrors or else they won't get their salary bonus next Tuesday. But Babelios found the same story written by Ed Twain-#283456, posted on his Fusion account, 234 years ago."

"Damn it!" Yuan flipped the table. "Squad 7, wipe him clean and send him back home."

#

No one knew exactly when stories got strange.

Ideas were so over-implemented that it became profitable to write stories about the wackiest and most stupid things. The less it made sense, the more successful it would be.

Artists went from modernism to postmodernism to post-postmodernism to post-post-postmodernism. Art became blotches of paint more incoherent by the century.

Even in Yuan's time, metafiction had become popular. Writers now thought it was original to experiment with self-referencing their story or the greater world, to break fourth walls, to parody other fictional works. It would be really cheap if I did something like that right now.

Yuan had joined the Seekers of Creativity to prove <NAME> wrong. It didn't matter what she actually believed. And if the organization succeeded in their goal of finding a truly original thought, she thought that maybe it could help cure her disorder too.

The days passed. <NAME> continued burning books, believing there was no more originality left in the world and that this was the only way to find more. Yuan continued working for the Seekers of Creativity, believing she was destined to find something <NAME> couldn't burn.

#

Yuan thought about how the world got creative in everyday speech to refer to particular things.

It started with names. With the help of the world's (endless) geniuses, the USA District developed a cryptographical system similar to the one implemented in banking accounts to give a unique, foolproof tag to every citizen of Geopolis, and faith was put in the beautiful infallibility of prime numbers.

Well, the tag system worked for now, but its flaw was that it was still sequential. The realm of integer numbers was infinite, but we didn't have infinite time to say a number after someone's name in our everyday lives, did we?

The Username Problem—where people spent an average of three weeks to find an original username—got so bad that Geopolis citizens were now legally required to use their names with their tags when signing up for any account. Some legislative advocates suggested getting rid of names altogether and calling everyone by their serial number instead. But names were still useful at the local level, and people with lower serial numbers would have an advantage in life. No one wanted to be forced to clear their calendars when someone was introducing themselves to them. Besides, the serial name system would accelerate what modern philosophers called the "Ocean Paradox." Humanity would be no different than the fish in the sea—all individuals equally unimportant.

"You're special, you know that?" Yuan's mother had told her when she was young—along with a million billion other mothers to their children in the world.

Instead of referring to the names of locations, people sometimes used the exact latitude and longitude of coordinates of places to explain where they went on vacation. Perhaps names were endless, but the Earth's surface was still finite.

People were always trying to find a way to connect the infinite to the finite. That's how it was these days, Yuan felt.

The world was especially shocked when it learned Albert Einstein's ideas weren't his.

"This is outrageous!" they said.

The government of Geopolis investigated other historical figures. Aristotle had copied from an unnamed philosopher who was his peer in Plato's Academy. Newton received "his" ideas from a Sanskrit script that had already outlined the laws of motion thousands of years before him, translated by Indians two centuries before his time who passed on their discoveries to Jesuit missionaries who brought them back to London. Ten others before Darwin had written papers about the theory of evolution, but they were just unpublished and so obscure from remote locations that they were never read.

They were found using Babelios. The advanced super-algorithm that scoured the world, both offline and online sources, for all works and thoughts by mankind. It was originally a plagiarism detector, but when Dr. Kim-#812346 made a breakthrough in his patented NeuroNet Array technology (just the name and specific parameters were patented, the technology was independently developed by a dozen other computer scientists around the world according to Babelios, they just weren't as successful at commercializing it), the Babelios everyone knew today was born.

NeuroNet Array was based on the theory that human brainwaves—specifically the electromagnetic and quantum-scale activity within neurons—generated unique resonant quantum signatures when a person thought. These quantum signatures, a phenomenon Dr. Kim-#812346 called *quantum cognitive resonance* (QCR), subtly "tuned" into a global quantum field, allowing them to be detected and interpreted by advanced technologies. Since particles stayed entangled until "observed," they would remain readable until NeuroNet Array measured the fluctuations, meaning quantum activity from the past was unfailingly recorded, and Babelios could find information and thoughts from dead people. If a Tesla coil could generate an oscillating electric current with a magnetic field to transmit wireless electricity, so a structure can be built to read the fluctuations in the world of quantum particles to read data from human brain activity. Nothing in the macroscopic world escaped the influence of the microscopic.

No, Dr. Kim-#812346 wasn't planning to take over Geopolis with mind control. It wasn't there yet.

What *was* here already was a new world where no thought was safe. Yuan's boss told her

the story of how the Seekers of Creativity bought Babelios from Dr. Kim-#812346 for… well, the number was classified. But it was a lot. Now the shadow organization could use it to find every fleeting whisper of a thought, every floating memory of every mind on Earth and run it against a mythically enormous library of data to check if something someone thought was truly original.

For each mind, their competition, of course, was every other human in the infinitely dense crowd of citizens in the timeless city planet. Seeker Officers were commanded to invade people's homes and raid private memories. A lover's kiss, a loved one's death… *OK, we've seen it all before. There's nothing new here. Onto the next house.* That was their job.

Dr. Kim-#812346 knew not to give Babelios a voice or even a visual representation. Countless works of media had already done so, usually making them evil and tainting the idea of an omnipotent AI. Once again, the world of overused ideas was working against him. It was better to make Babelios remain formless, voiceless, its nature up to the interpretation of its million billion subjects. (Even though there were probably ten thousand authors in the various districts of Geopolis that did the same for the omnipotent AIs in *their* stories…)

The truth was that just last year, it was discovered that Babelios's database of human ideas and the Library of Babel were already a 100% complete match.

That's when Yuan started getting symptoms.

#

Yuan's disorder was getting worse. She tried memory-erasure injections of "Little Medieval Village" PC5-48G5, a drug that made your world smaller. She tried the doctor-prescribed vignette journal therapy: "Yuan-#325678, all you have to do is write down your every thought in a notebook. The more, the better. When you compare your words with others, you'll see just how unique you are! It should help ease the symptoms of your disorder."

The trauma didn't end there. She knew Babelios was watching, and that it was already finding millions of copies of her sentences by other people around the world. She also knew anything she wrote was already written in the Library of Babel, a database that Babelios also had access to. *Look, Yuan,* it whispered to her. *Oh, sorry. I mean Yuan-#325678. I can't forget I already told the past 10 Yuans the same thing. Anyway, look: what you wrote about the flavour of your breakfast eggs today is in the Library of Babel, page 44 of 410, in a book titled* rvutzwwuebepav,uskctway, *volume 32 on shelf 1 of wall 4 of Hexagon—OK, the name of the Hexagon is too long for me to say. But you wrote,* my eggs tasted like velvindra mixed with wonderment sauce*. You even tried to invent a colour to try to fool me. Like that would work.*

You do know that anything you ever write, even if a string of purely random gibberish characters, is already published in the Library, right? And in the vignette journals of probably 3 million other people. Maybe a small percentage of them Yuans. Maybe a small percentage of those Yuans with your same exact face. I can give you their addresses, do you want them?

You're not special.

"Stop!" Yuan yelled at her imaginary conversation with Babelios.

Oh… how do I break this to you? About 324 Yuans said the same thing.

Yuan cursed. She had to get out. She had to do *something*. Maybe start burning people, if she wanted to go <NAME>'s route but to the extreme. She was starting to see <NAME>'s point. Geopolis simply had too many people. Anything she did was pointless.

I think 23 Yuans had the same conclusion, said Babelios.

Yuan wanted to do something erratic. Something to escape this infinite regress of parallelism. The number had to go down—she thought the more random things she did, the less likely Babelios would have seen others had done it. She was at her desk. She grabbed her keyboard

and slammed it on the edge, snapping it in two. She yelled gibberish—then said it quietly—then said it loud! She counted numbers out of order. She ran outside her apartment and entered the endless torrent of rain of Geopolis's Pacific District and screamed and—people on the skywalk of her street must have thought she was crazy. *Uh oh,* they thought. *Another victim to the late stages of Unoriginal Disorder. Poor girl.*

Anything to get the number down. Anything to get 0 Yuans.

She called her Mom—then realized that was predictable. So she hung up. She threw her phone off her apartment balcony. *Take that!* she thought. How many Yuans would have done that? It took about 7.8 seconds to reach the bottom, and she imagined its falling, mirrored image on the glass of her skyscraper, one of many which formed Geopolis's boundless skyline.

She thought that should be enough. No one knew the true extent of Geopolis's population, but she was willing to bet her life that this sequence of events was truly unique. That maybe a Yuan in the Australia District had only managed to reach 7.7 seconds, or a Yuan in the Southwest Atlantic Subdistrict had overshot and reached 7.9 seconds. Everyone was a tired monkey on a worn-out typewriter—but every once in a while, a monkey could scratch their butt in a particular way, then eat a banana, then continue to do a sequence of random things, and then compound this until their particular string of memories from birth to death would be astronomically unique compared to all others, like a geneticist comparing a strand of DNA that shared nothing with all known strands. Maybe two of them would have produced *Hamlet*, but one would have written Act IV first, and the other would have written Act II first.

OK, she thought. *I've discovered something everyone knew already—that all lives are unique. Wow, Yuan, that's so impressive.*

Yuan thought about her brother, who succumbed to a different disease and had ended his life two years ago. He told her, "Life is just an endless cycle. Every day is the same, or every day is something I've seen before. My office at work doesn't change, the people I choose to be with don't change—because strangers are scary and relationships take time to develop. You and <NAME> argue about the originality of ideas, but what about the originality of experiences within one person's life? You remember how I took a trip over the ocean and stranded myself in the Tibetan Plateau Subdistrict? I was forced to write ideas in notebooks instead of digitally. It gave me a little hope, something new to fight the tiredness of living."

"What changed?" Yuan asked him.

He looked defeated. "There were a hundred others at the same temple as me, doing the same thing."

She thought of him now. She gripped the lucky coin he had gifted to her all those years ago when they were children. *Flip a coin,* he had said. *See how in each successive moment between when it's in the air and when it lands on your hand, like the infinite rectangles of zero width under a calculus curve, you don't know which one it's going to be. Randomness in each second is the one true source of originality.*

A million billion strings of light suspended all the currently flipped coins in the world, with all their owners waiting for the outcome in each Planck instant. They glowed like the tendrils of a jellyfish, rigidly and one-dimensionally straight, hanging from the dark clouds of the night sky. They blurred against each other so that time itself wasn't discrete; the power of the Crowd was recursively continuous. Yuan imagined that in every moment of her coin's future path in the air, someone else's coin was in that same position somewhere in Geopolis.

Whatever. Yuan flipped her coin anyway and got tails. As she expected. OK, her brother had been half right—she guessed with 99.999% certainty it would be tails, as if forcing herself to

believe in something against her will. But that tiny sliver left was everything he had been trying to tell her. It didn't matter—she still didn't believe it. When there were more souls in the world than God could conceive, nothing was random.

Yuan had put a hand on her brother's shoulder, aware of the human spirit's dilemma between the desire to belong and the desire to feel important—and flipped a mental coin and gambled: "It's okay. Seeking spiritual salvation in a foreign, mystical place is a common idea. It's practically cliché in media."

She picked wrong. On days she missed her brother, she really wished she hadn't said that. She didn't know what she was thinking.

In her palm, the lucky coin's mass hadn't changed over the years, but somehow it felt different, as if each coin sparse in the city dangled on a string of light but this one was cut loose. Was it all in her head? It felt heavier.

Did originality add weight?

#

It was a cold winter evening when <NAME> admitted to Yuan that she was wrong.

"I found this little girl's stuffed bear," she said. "I told her, 'It's one of the most common ideas of all time. I have to burn it.'

'No!' she cried. I asked her *why not?* Everyone in Geopolis knew of the oversaturation of ideas, I didn't have to explain it, even to a kid. But then she said, 'My grandpa gave it to me before he died. I grew up with it. I don't care if other kids have a teddy bear. I don't even care if they have the same model or if they gave it the same exact name. This one's mine.'

Surely, she's not the only kid in Geopolis who thought that. But then I looked around her room. Saw Lego in a corner, a copy of *The Little Prince* that her mother used to read to her in another. I didn't see things I had to burn anymore. I saw ideas that had been deliberately reused to give all kids the same childhood experience.

I gave the teddy bear back. She hugged it fiercely, worried that one of her last trinkets linking to her grandfather's memory had almost vanished from the universe. It was impossible to replace it. I didn't burn it—I just couldn't.

I don't want my future kids to not have Lego or classic books or teddy bears. Maybe this nostalgia is what's powering the infinite recycle of ideas, maybe it applies to the whole human race. I don't know. Maybe we don't always have to restart."

Yuan was moved. "I'll send an application to the Seekers about this right away. Sometimes, if you believe you've found an original idea, you can submit it to the Seekers for approval and earn a reward."

<NAME> laughed softly, as if she already knew it would fail.

"I doubt it would work. It's probably been sent to them a million times already. Maybe by a million girls with teddy bears, a million girls who burn books, and a million Seeker Officers named Yuan. You can't explain why some ideas are original, it has to be felt, even if they aren't."

"I'll write a story about you."

"Don't give them my name!" <NAME> blurted. "Censor it or something. I know how you Seekers operate—you'd do anything to search inside my head. Censoring also makes Babelios take a bit longer to index and search for the ideas. Maybe it'll take 0.001 extra seconds, but it's worth it. I want my memories protected, even for just another moment. They're mine."

Yuan got to work. She tried not to think about how the story she was writing could have applied to anyone else in Geopolis. That she was a drop of water in an ocean, and there was no reason a reader would choose her as the main character in this world when everyone else had the

same experience as her. She was only writing a story about <NAME> because Yuan knew her. But she could have picked Mira Calderon in the East Philippines District or Zayden Okoye in the Nigeria District. She didn't know them, but this story could have been about them too.

As she finished her story, Yuan realized something. Even if by a microscopic chance no one else on Geopolis had made it, this whole story was in the Library of Babel, word for word. In a way, it was already published, though by heartless mathematical algorithms instead of humans with a predisposition for art. You just had to find it.

Huh. Finding it will take forever, Yuan thought. *I have the full story in my hands right now, for free. It's finished. And even if it's already out there, I can still call it mine. It has a physical weight in my hands.*

A smile crept up her lips. She was a Monkey, through and through.

#

"So why did you want to chat?" asked Marvin Snow, across from her at their café patio table, holding a warm latte in his hand. Squad 7 had wiped his memory clean. To him, this was the first time they were meeting.

Yuan tried to remember what Babelios had told her when she queried it at Seeker HQ for the subconscious sources of his story.

The magenta boots. When Marvin was seven, his mother, Ines, bought him rain boots in a loud magenta from a clearance bin. "Now I'll never lose you in the Crowd," she said. Marvin wore them indoors, to bed, and to his mother's nanotherapy appointments, where he sat swinging them under a waiting-room chair. Their three cats, Biscuit, Taco, and a one-eyed tom named Bao, each claimed a boot as a bed whenever he kicked them off. One boot usually held two cats.

The Queen of Mirrors. Ines hated what the illness did to her face, and one week she covered every mirror in the apartment with bed sheets. Marvin, scared of the sheet-draped ghosts in the hallway, was told by his mother: "That's just the Queen of Mirrors. She only shows you the worst version of yourself. Don't take her seriously." Marvin started telling stories at bedtime about the cats, in their magenta boots, sent to defeat her, and Ines laughed until she coughed.

The bonus. His father, Teo, worked double shifts at a warehouse and kept saying, "If the bonus comes through next Tuesday, we take your mother to the neo-lake." He said it so often that it became a household joke. When the cats knocked a glass off the counter or opened a drawer and rummaged through their cereal boxes, he'd wag a finger at them: "No bonus for you." Marvin's bedtime stories absorbed this, and soon the cats were employees who had to defeat the Queen or forfeit their pay. His mother said it was the most realistic part.

Ines died on a Sunday.

The bonus came through on Tuesday, two days too late for the lake trip. Teo stood in the kitchen, holding the envelope, and couldn't speak. Marvin, nine years old, put on his boots and said, "The cats did their job. They're supposed to get paid."

"Hello?" It was Marvin, waving his hand. "What are you thinking about?"

Do you want to hear the inspiration for the same story Ed Twain-#283456 wrote, 234 years ago? He saw a unique painting at a museum once, and that gave him the idea. That's all.

Yuan shook the thoughts out of her head and sipped her coffee. For some reason, her disorder didn't start an episode this time. Her mind felt clear.

"Sorry," she said. "Listen, I'll get straight to the point. I work for a publishing company, and we're really struggling to find the next big story for our audience. We're very fond of the Classicism Eras. I heard from your wife you had an original story idea in that style."

It was a lie, but it was enough.

His eyes lit up. “Yes! I’m glad you heard about that. I wanted to write a story about cats with magenta boots forced to fight an evil Queen of Mirrors or else they won’t get their salary bonus next Tuesday. I know, I know, it sounds ridiculous, but it can’t be more random than some of the incoherent stuff they’re outputting these days. I think it has potential, and I have my reasons why.”

Yuan sipped her coffee and leaned forward, ready to listen. She smiled.

“I’d love to hear more about it,” she said.